



were left fuming, as was Union Minister of State for IT and Telecom Jyotiraditya Scindia.

Ever since the last date of filing of the nominations, Nath has been chopper-hopping in his traditional fiefdom of Mahakoshal. Leaving behind his jet-setting ways, Nath touches down in Betul to urge his party workers to get into the heat of the battle. While awestruck workers still find it awkward to interact with him freely, Nath is content that his job has been made easier by the split in the Gondwana Ganatantra Party, the tribal outfit that proved to be the party's nemesis in the region. The last time the BJP won in 2003, the tribal party won only three seats but garnered a sizeable vote and put paid to the Congress's hopes in a dozen others. Having walked away with the largest chunk of party nominations for his supporters, it is now up to Nath to deliver the seats. The next largest number of tickets has been bagged by Digvijay and Pachauri supporters, followed by Scindia and Arjun Singh. After the month-long process of selecting candidates, the Congress finally junked the Antony Committee recommendations, threw out all criteria

HOUSE DIVIDED

The endorsement of Kamal Nath as the Congress's chief ministerial candidate by senior leaders like Digvijay Singh and others has left the party a divided house; aspirants like Suresh Pachauri, Ajeya Singh and Jyotiraditya Scindia are livid.



UMA BHARATI'S BJ THREATENS TO CAUSE
A BANG BUT IT COULD END UP AS A DUD

and adopted "winnability" as its only yardstick. "The division of tickets according to the might of respective chieftains is an old Congress phenomenon. Why be surprised?" says a senior Congress leader.

The only problem for the Con-

gress is that its old formula hasn't been coupled with a new vigour. After ruling uninterrupted for 10 years from 1993, the party finally bowed to anti-incumbency and a renewed BJP in the last elections. Having sat out five years in the Opposition for the first time ever in the state, it has failed to rake up issues that could make life difficult for the ruling BJP. Over a dozen ministers in the Chouhan Cabinet are facing probes by the anti-corruption ombudsman Lokayukta. Barring his pet schemes of providing subsidies for the weddings of poor girls and financial security for girl children, most of the populist schemes have failed to leave a mark on the electorate's mindscape. Still Chouhan gets into the rough and tumble of the campaign with reasonable confidence. If the Congress fails to come to power again, it would have only itself to blame.